United Nations S/PV.9890

Security Council

Eighteenth year

Provisional

9890th meeting
Thursday, 3 April 2025, 10 a.m.
New York

President:	Mr. Bonnafont	(France)
Members:	Algeria	Mr. Bendjama
	China	Mr. Sun Lei
	Denmark	Ms. Landi
	Greece	Mr. Sekeris
	Guyana	Ms. Persaud
	Pakistan	Mr. Ahmad
	Panama	Mr. Alfaro de Alba
	Republic of Korea	Mr. Hwang
	Russian Federation	Ms. Evstigneeva
	Sierra Leone	Mr. Kanu
	Slovenia	Ms. Jurečko
	Somalia	Mr. Abdullahi
	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland	Ms. Jambert-Gray
	United States of America	Mr. Kelley

Agenda

Peace consolidation in West Africa

Report of the Secretary-General on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (S/2025/187)

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The meeting was called to order at 10.05 a.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

Peace consolidation in West Africa

Report of the Secretary-General on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (S/2025/187)

The President (*spoke in French*): In accordance with article 39 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the following briefers to participate in this meeting: Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for West Africa and the Sahel and Head of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel; and Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi, Founding Director of Women Advocates Research and Documentation Center.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

I wish to draw the attention of Council members to document S/2025/187, which contains the report of the Secretary-General on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel.

I now give the floor to Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, whom I thank for being here and for the statement that he is to give us.

Mr. Simão (*spoke in French*): I have the honour to present the report (S/2025/187) of the Secretary-General on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS).

I congratulate France on its presidency of the Council for the month of April and wish it a successful presidency. I would also like to welcome the presence of Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi, Director of Women Advocates Research and Documentation Center, and commend to her for her important work in the region.

In January, I travelled to Maiduguri, Nigeria, with my colleague Mr. Abdou Abarry, Special Representative and Head of the United Nations Regional Office for Central Africa (UNOCA), to take part in the fifth Lake Chad Basin Governors Forum. We also visited Bama, a city that once had a population of 300,000; it has since been devastated by Boko Haram and is home to extensive camps for displaced persons, which include a school compound sheltering more than 100,000 displaced people. The displaced people conveyed to us their hopes for peace and development, which reflects the successful endeavours of the four countries of the Lake Chad basin — Cameroon, the Niger, Nigeria and Chad — in combating terrorism and fostering stability. Nonetheless, concerns about the lack of educational and employment opportunities remain, with the region facing the challenges of terrorism and climate change. The Governors Forum introduced new mechanisms for financing, reconciliation, reintegration and stabilization, while underscoring the importance of ongoing regional collaboration.

During our visit, stakeholders stressed the need for continued diplomatic efforts and financial support to maintain the Multinational Joint Task Force — currently the only operational security mechanism in the region. Although good offices continue to be used with a view to keeping the coalition together, the Niger recently announced its withdrawal from the Task Force. The announcement comes at a time when security is the region's main concern, even though considerable investment in military resources and cross-border cooperation have been capable of consolidating State authority in some areas of the Central Sahel.

The joint force established by the member States of the Alliance of Sahel States to coordinate operations is contributing to stabilization and creating conditions conducive to bolstering State presence. In Burkina Faso, for example, the authorities state that they have control of more than 70 per cent of the country, which has allowed them to resettle approximately 1 million displaced people and reopen more than 200 health centres. However, progress regionwide is fragile, owing in particular to an upsurge in terrorist attacks in the northern border areas, which are targeted mainly at the coastal States of Benin and Togo. Although the standby force of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) is not yet fully operational, the joint patrols and the interest of Côte d'Ivoire and Ghana in strengthening their cooperation on security are encouraging. The reconfiguration of the Accra Initiative affords a unique opportunity to further regional cooperation on security. The implementation of resolution 2719 (2023) has the potential to contribute greatly to the fight against terrorism.

(*spoke in English*)

Against that background, Mali has launched a disarmament, demobilization and reintegration process, aimed at demobilizing the 3,000 former combatants, with 2,000 having joined the armed forces. In the Niger, more than 700 leaders gathered for the Assises Nationales, to set goals for the transition process. In Burkina Faso, the Prime Minister is consulting with various actors, and Mauritania's President has started a national dialogue with opposition parties. Those important developments are key amid ongoing challenges. Supporting dialogue is essential for addressing root causes, promoting social cohesion and fostering inclusive decision-making.

I recently visited Mali and Mauritania to emphasize rebuilding trust across the region. Mauritania's leaders are committed to supporting dialogue in the region and, in Mali, the authorities invited the United Nations to support upcoming elections, assuring me that preparations are moving forward. My interlocutors in both countries welcomed the strengthened cooperation with United Nations country teams, in line with our advocacy for pragmatic and adapted approaches to support national development goals under the leadership of the United Nations integrated strategy for the Sahel.

Still in Mali, the appointment of a Minister in charge of elections, a budget allocation for elections and the review of the voter registration signal progress towards a return to constitutional order. In Guinea, the transitional authorities have reiterated their intention to organize elections by the end of 2025, following the adoption of a new Constitution and the conduct of a general census. Those are positive commitments that deserve encouragement and support.

In Ghana, President John Dramani Mahama appointed a Special Envoy to the Alliance of Sahel States and has visited several countries in the region to reinforce cooperation, including between the Alliance of Sahel States and the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), to support citizens reliant on free border transit for their livelihoods. I also plan to visit Accra soon and to continue consultations with authorities in Burkina Faso and the Niger. ECOWAS and the countries of the Alliance of Sahel States are preparing for negotiations on their separation, effective 29 January, with a transition period set by ECOWAS until end of July. While ECOWAS is keeping the door open, the Alliance is deepening internal cooperation, both sides aiming to maintain the benefits of regional integration, especially the freedom of movement. Those are encouraging developments indeed.

As ECOWAS celebrates its fiftieth anniversary, it remains a key model for political and economic regional integration. Following elections in Senegal and Ghana last year, both countries' leaderships are focused on translating their popular mandates into governance and economic reforms. In the Gambia, a recent meeting between President Adama Barrow and opposition leader Ousainou Darboe raised

hopes that the country is heading towards the adoption of a new constitution, consistent with its commitment to democratic reform. I plan to visit Banjul soon to support efforts to consolidate peace and democracy in the country.

Several other pressing issues require our attention. Côte d'Ivoire's presidential election in October this year raises concerns about inclusivity, given the memories of the 2010-2011 electoral crisis and the violence encountered during the 2020 polls. In Guinea-Bissau, profound disagreements over the end of the current presidential term, the timing of 2025 elections and the legitimacy of State institutions pose serious risks for a peaceful process. I commend the Peacebuilding Commission's efforts in Guinea-Bissau and will continue to work with ECOWAS to promote dialogue on those issues of contention.

I am concerned by reports of unarmed civilians being targeted in the fight against terrorism, which undermines the rule of law and counteracts efforts to combat violent extremism. Reports of human rights violations, including the silencing of activists, journalists and political leaders, persist. Despite progress in extending State authority, thousands of schools remain closed owing to insecurity, hindering development for young people. UNOWAS will continue advocating for the implementation of resolution 2601 (2021) on the protection of education in conflict.

On the other hand, the decline in resources for humanitarian assistance to populations affected by terrorism and climate change continues, with no signs of stabilizing or even reversing. Efforts to address the root causes of conflict and mitigate the impact of climate changes should be supported. The expulsion of migrants converging in some countries highlights the fragile socioeconomic context across the region, especially for the most vulnerable people. We must encourage the relevant countries to collaborate to reduce the suffering of those migrants, particularly women.

(*spoke in French*)

While the region's rising socioeconomic indicators are promising, they are largely driven by resource extraction and food production. However, challenges remain, such as high inflation, growing indebtedness, climate shocks and limited fiscal capacity, reducing the ability of Governments to invest in essential services and infrastructure. Building long-term resilience requires comprehensive approaches and partnerships that prioritize macroeconomic stability and inclusive growth, as well as stronger economic governance.

UNOWAS continues to promote good governance, human rights and the women and peace and security and youth, peace and security agendas. In March, as part of the "arbre à palabre" framework to promote dialogue on regional challenges, UNOWAS organized a meeting with anti-corruption agencies to discuss governance, development and security issues. In February, UNOWAS and UNOCA jointly organized a conference on the dynamics between farmers and herders, during which issues of governance, insecurity and social cohesion were addressed.

UNOWAS also supports maritime security, which is essential in the fight against transnational organized crime. We provided technical support to ECOWAS and the Economic Community of Central African States for the evaluation of the Yaoundé Architecture on maritime security, which is expected to be validated this month.

A growing number of countries have enacted legislation to promote women's participation in politics and decision-making. Senegal has one of the highest rates of female representation in Parliament, and Ghana adopted a law on gender parity last year. However, the implementation of national action plans on the women and peace and security agenda remains slow in some countries. UNOWAS will continue to advocate for the political and economic empowerment of women and youth through

education, skills development and job creation, in particular through the Women, Youth, Peace and Security Working Group in West Africa and the Sahel.

As Chair of the Cameroon-Nigeria Mixed Commission, I would like to highlight a crucial achievement in conflict prevention and peacebuilding. Cameroon and Nigeria are working together to resolve the final areas of disagreement. We are currently working to launch the final phase of the pillars and are supporting United Nations country teams in drawing up a comprehensive development programme for border populations. That programme aims to transform the border into a development corridor, promoting cross-border cooperation, peace and stability in the region. I reiterate my appeals to the Council to support that exemplary achievement for peace between the two major countries.

Eighty years after its establishment, the United Nations remains more vital than ever. In the face of multiple and persistent challenges, our collective efforts are essential. With the Council's continued support, we must unite to serve the people of West Africa and the Sahel.

The President (*spoke in French*): I thank Mr. Simão for his comprehensive briefing on the situation in the region and the work of the Office.

I now give the floor to Ms. Akiyode-Afolabi.

Ms. Akiyode-Afolabi: It is with great pleasure that I am here to brief the Security Council on the status of women's rights in Africa and the priorities for the advancement of girls and women in the region.

The West African region accounts for approximately one third of Africa's population. The region's population is equivalent to 5.67 per cent of the total world population, and the region ranks second among subregions in Africa, ranked by population. Of that population, approximately 50 per cent are women. The region has suffered military rule, undemocratic Governments, wars and conflicts, putting the enjoyment of the rights of women and girls at risk.

I am here to say that, despite the fact that progress has been made in key areas of women's development, gender equality remains unfinished business. Women in several West African countries still face numerous challenges, including harmful traditional practices, poverty and a lack of access to education. Many African traditional communities still conceive the duty of a woman to be primarily that of childbearing and child-rearing.

Countries such as Burkina Faso, Cabo Verde, the Gambia, Ghana, Guinea-Bissau, Mauritania, Senegal and Sierra Leone have tried to close the gender gap in primary school enrolment, which is impressive and necessary for the growth of the rights aspired to. However, in many countries, the youth illiteracy rate among girls is still almost twice as high as that of boys. Women and girls in West Africa have a 58 per cent chance of not being enrolled in secondary school and a 20 per cent chance of beginning to bear children as a teenager, and they can expect to earn less than their male counterparts, regardless of the sector in which they work.

I will focus on the following six fundamental women's rights issues, which are also related to issues of peace and security: women's rights to bodily autonomy, freedom from violence, equal pay and opportunities, access to education, the right to fully participate in public life and issues around women and peace and security. All those issues are shaped by our times and contexts in different countries.

West Africa has faced a lot of conflicts over time, and the impact of those conflicts — the recent threats of coups, the military takeover in places like Niger, the insurgency in Nigeria and other issues such as banditry, kidnapping and the decline in State security — have continued to define the enjoyment of rights in the region. All those phenomena have been normalized; consequently, what we see is

the violation of women's rights, with women becoming collateral damage and their bodily integrity been trampled upon. Several women who were violated in the early 1990s war in Liberia and Sierra Leone have yet to rebuild their lives. The impacts have led to untimely deaths, and some women have ended up on the street and have suffered injustice and poverty, with no help in sight. More than 280 girls were taken away from a school in Nigeria; as of today, more than 50 per cent of the girls have yet to be returned to school or to their parents. Many similar situations abound.

While institutions have been built over time to deal with truth and reintegration, the lack of political will and government failure to invest in and prioritize ensuring respect for the rights of women and girls continue to undermine success in addressing the post-conflict impact. As of today, most countries in the region have enacted legislation to promote women's rights and have built institutions, such as sexual assault referral centres in some countries such as Nigeria, while in Ghana, more organizations are collaborating with the Government to support women and girls who suffered violence perpetrated against them by intimate partners. Sierra Leone has put in place a gender equality and women's empowerment act to address women's participation and violence against women. Likewise, Ghana has adopted a new gender parity act. Liberia is also strong in supporting institutions; however, women's rights are still adversely affected.

New forms of, and trends in, violations have emerged. Women face violence facilitated by technology. Women's voices are being shut down. Such disruption has made women more vulnerable to harassment. In addition to the fact that women's voices are being shut down, we are also seeing more harassment by State and non-State actors. Currently in Nigeria, women's rights are being violated at the highest levels, with a female senator, Senator Natasha Akpoti, being suspended from daring to speak out against the leadership of the National Assembly. The data being reported is also showing that femicide is on the rise in the region. Climate change has also fuelled violations of women's health and rights in the Sahel, with the prevalence of trafficking in women and girls who are escaping conflict and poverty.

Although women are increasingly represented in parliaments, particularly in the Senegalese Parliament, and the proportion of female members of parliament has doubled in the past few years, women's equal political participation remains a major challenge throughout the region. Women's representation in parliaments increased only marginally, from 13 per cent in 2007 to 16 per cent in 2017, and there are still disparities. The scant representation of women in the West African region was also underscored by the failure to vote into law bills promoting increased gender participation and women's rights in the National Assemblies of the Gambia and Nigeria, respectively. Recently, we saw pushback in the Gambia against the already adopted act banning female genital mutilation; the gains made over years are under major threat. That is why it is important for us to focus on further promoting the human rights of women. Forced marriages and torture of widows still occur in many West African countries, denying young women and girls equality of opportunities and leading to high rates of maternal mortality.

In order to create meaningful change, it is essential to implement and enforce development policies that integrate women into the formal economy in West Africa, and we have seen strategies of that kind that have worked in other places, such as Tanzania and Uganda. One such approach is gender budgeting, which means that there is a need for Governments to invest more in budgeting for gender equality issues.

Another important issue is the fact that one in four women lack reproductive autonomy, or the power to decide when, if at all, to have children. That is due to the unmet family planning needs, along with low contraceptive use, which stands at 17 per cent, as compared to 64 per cent globally. The lack of basic infrastructure and public services exacerbates the burden of domestic and care work, which traditionally

fall to women. And we think that it is important that women spend six times more time than men on unpaid care work, doing things to which we need to respond. That disparity creates significant economic and social challenges for women.

One out of every 32 girls born in West and Central Africa will die because of a pregnancy-related complication in their lifetime. In addition, for every maternal death in the region, there are at least 30 women who suffer long-term disabilities. According to a study conducted in four countries in West Africa, less than 1 per cent of women have ever been screened for disease. As a result, only 21 per cent of African women survive disease, as compared to 70 per cent in the United States. One of the leading causes of maternal mortality is unsafe abortion. An estimated 90,000 abortions are performed annually in Sierra Leone — a country of more than 8 million people — according to research by the African Population and Health Research Centre. About 10 per cent of the country's maternal deaths, affecting 717 of every 100,000 births, are caused by unsafe abortions. There are also other issues that I believe we should focus on, including women's financial development.

In countries that have experienced war and where national action plans have been adopted in pursuit of resolution 1325 (2000), there is a need to do more in terms of the participation and representation of women in peace and security conversations. Still, as of today, very few women are represented at the peace table. In advancing priorities, Governments should commit to national gender strategies that are inclusive and that allow for women's rights to thrive, which is important when it comes to implementing legislative reforms. Designated courts must be established in different countries to address post-war violence and conflict, which women face on a daily basis. There is also a need to work on retention in education, which is critical to ending the violence and wars that we are seeing. I must say that there is a need to have a much more holistic framework to address the issue of inclusion, the prevention of violence, the protection of people and ensuring that the peace architecture is gender sensitive.

I want to conclude by saying that now is the time to do more to support women's participation in peace processes and include more women in politics so that they can determine and define their lives and the world in which they want to live. The time is now.

The President (*spoke in French*): I thank Ms. Akiyode-Afolabi for her very clear and relevant briefing.

I shall now give the floor to those members of the Council who wish to make statements.

Mr. Kanu (Sierra Leone): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the three African members of the Security Council, namely, Algeria, Somalia and my own country, Sierra Leone, plus Guyana (A3+).

We thank Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS), for his comprehensive and valuable briefing. We take note of Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi's contribution.

The A3+ takes note of the report of the Secretary-General on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (S/2025/187). The States of West Africa and the Sahel continue to demonstrate a resolute determination to improve the well-being of their citizens by addressing security challenges, strengthening democratic governance and advancing socioeconomic development. Allow me to highlight three key points on how the Security Council and the wider international system can support and enhance peace and stability in the region.

First, we must leverage the comparative advantage of regional security initiatives. The A3+ remains gravely concerned about the rising number and intensity of attacks perpetrated by terrorist groups, which have resulted in increasing fatalities and destabilization. The threat of such attacks spreading to West African coastal States is particularly alarming. We commend the Security Council for its swift and united response in condemning the recent attacks in Benin, Burkina Faso, Mali and, most recently, the Niger. We extend our condolences to the victims of those heinous acts, and we affirm the need for the Council's continued unity in addressing terrorism in all its forms.

The evolving security landscape has been marked by growing geopolitical tensions. In that context, the focus must remain on strengthening regional security mechanisms grounded in national ownership and based on cooperation among the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), the African Union, neighbouring countries and other subregional initiatives. The region's stability must reflect collaborative approaches aligned with the priorities of its peoples. We commend the efforts of those States in the region that are pursuing coordinated and collaborative counter-terrorism strategies. While security operations are vital, long-term stability requires addressing the root causes of extremism, including socioeconomic disparities, weak governance and local grievances.

Accordingly, we advocate for a comprehensive regional strategy that enhances cross-border cooperation, intelligence-sharing — including with neighbouring countries — and the operational effectiveness of frameworks such as the Multinational Joint Task Force and the Accra Initiative. We reiterate our call for increased financial and technical support to bolster States' capacities, particularly at joint border control points. Strengthening national and cross-border efforts across West Africa and the Sahel remains essential to regional and global security.

Secondly, fostering political stability is key to durable peace. We welcome the political stability in the region, while recognizing that States continue to grapple with transitions and institutional reform processes aimed at promoting governance systems that respond effectively to geopolitical and socioeconomic challenges. We commend Special Representative Simão for his proactive use of good offices to facilitate dialogue, including with ECOWAS and in the context of national elections. Such efforts promote inclusivity, reconciliation and national ownership, which are all fundamental to sustainable peace. We also applaud the African Union's continued efforts in promoting peace, security and development.

The A3+ welcomes ECOWAS's strategic approach to addressing the withdrawal of the countries of the Alliance of Sahel States and acknowledges the facilitative role played by Senegal and Togo. We also commend the constructive and pragmatic approaches adopted by Ghana and other ECOWAS member States through bilateral engagements. We encourage sustained efforts towards a cooperative understanding to manage shared challenges and geographical realities. We are pleased with the momentum of national dialogue processes, including the involvement of religious leaders to advance cohesion. We commend Ghana on its peaceful elections and the initiation of a constitutional review process. We also recognize the steps taken by various countries to facilitate peaceful transitions and call for the timely implementation of national road maps towards constitutional order. In that vein, the A3+ reiterates its call for all States to continue to uphold the rule of law, adhere to inclusive governance processes and ensure full respect for human rights. We underscore the pivotal role of civil society in strengthening democratic norms and reiterate the call for the immediate release of all arbitrarily detained individuals.

Thirdly, integrating responses to threat multipliers is critical for sustaining peace. The A3+ emphasizes the need for a comprehensive and preventive approach to conflict in the region — one that addresses underlying drivers, such as poverty,

climate change, food and water scarcity and systemic economic inequalities. Those factors not only hinder development but also intensify social tensions and increase the likelihood of violent conflict.

The situation in the Sahel remains dire, especially for the millions of forcibly displaced persons. We renew our call on international partners, including international financial institutions, to scale up humanitarian assistance to meet the needs of internally displaced persons and refugees throughout the region. Access to essential services, such as food production, education and healthcare, remains constrained. Those services are vital for building the region's future. We take note of the efforts by UNOWAS to advance the United Nations integrated strategy for the Sahel and call for renewed support towards its full operationalization. Building political and economic resilience, especially for women and youth, who are disproportionately impacted, must remain a priority. The A3+ calls for coherent and holistic strategies, integrating the efforts of national Governments, regional bodies, international organizations and local communities. Reforms addressing global trade and financial imbalances and building adaptive capacities at all levels are especially critical for regional resilience and long-term peace.

In conclusion, the A3+ commends Special Representative of the Secretary-General Simão for his continued leadership, particularly the progress made on the Cameroon-Nigeria Mixed Commission. And we look forward to the successful conclusion of that component of his mandate. We affirm our support to Special Representative of the Secretary-General Simão and to the work of UNOWAS. We reiterate our commitment to engaging constructively with all Council members to advance peace, security and development in West Africa and the Sahel in a manner that upholds national sovereignty and promotes regional cooperation and leadership.

Ms. Landi (Denmark): I would like to thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Simão for his briefing. I thank Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi for sharing her insights and, importantly, her recommendations for enhancing women's rights and inclusion in the region. We support those efforts wholeheartedly.

I also want to express my deepest condolences to the families of the victims of terrorism and violence across the region, including in the latest terrorist attack in Kokorou, the Niger, on 21 March. Denmark strongly condemns all acts of terrorism and violent extremism.

We also stress that counter-terrorism operations should not be used as an excuse to violate international humanitarian or human rights law. We call on all parties to uphold their obligations to protect civilians.

The briefings we have heard paint a complex picture of that region's contrasting realities and challenges, of fragility and resilience, and of progress and setbacks. What is clear is that sustained international attention is required to overcome them.

Allow me to make three points.

First, Denmark is gravely concerned about the deteriorating security situation in central Sahel. The intensification of violence in Burkina Faso and persistence of attacks across the wider Sahel region threaten sustainable peace and development. As always, civilians suffer most. The southward spread of instability must be curbed. The case is clear: only cooperation can address the cross-border conflict dynamics of the region. Denmark supports the role of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) as the regional convener. We urge all actors to strengthen joint security efforts, including through the ECOWAS Standby Force, the Accra Initiative and the Multinational Joint Task Force in the Lake Chad basin. Regional cooperation is not only a cornerstone for security; it enables the social, economic and political conditions required for peace. Denmark commends the role played by ECOWAS and its members to sustain free movement, despite new geopolitical realities, in the

interest of regional cohesion and prosperity. In that regard, we commend the efforts of Special Representative of the Secretary-General Simão to facilitate dialogue. We call on all actors to continue cooperating with his Office.

Secondly, no societal problem can be sustainably resolved without a responsive social contract. There are no shortcuts. Momentum for peace and prosperity is born out of accountable institutions, inclusive political processes and vibrant civic spaces. In that regard, we commend the latest elections in Ghana and Senegal. Denmark is deeply concerned about the restrictions on civic space and the repression of human rights across the Sahel region, including the prosecution of journalists and activists. The spread of misinformation and disinformation further threatens social cohesion and accountability. We echo the Special Representative of the Secretary-General's call for continuous, inclusive and meaningful dialogue in countries undergoing transitions and to advance their swift and full return to constitutional order. Every day that passes without such progress, will further embolden those benefiting from violence and instability. Only through inclusive governance and empowered communities can we effectively address the multiple underlying vulnerabilities and threats facing the region, including the adverse impacts of climate change. Denmark welcomes the proactive approach of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) to climate, peace and security. We encourage further actions in that regard.

Thirdly, the humanitarian situation in the Sahel region is deeply alarming. The intensification of violence, coupled with climatic shocks, has put tens of millions of people on the brink of food insecurity and has put women and girls at increased risk of gender-based violence. More than 6.5 million women, men and children are internally displaced across the Sahel. Those humanitarian conditions are compounded by a severe lack of access to basic services, including education and healthcare. Futures are put on hold, and women and girls bear the heaviest burden, as we have also heard today. That demands urgent action. Denmark calls on all parties across the region to urgently ensure rapid, safe and unhindered humanitarian access to civilians in need.

In conclusion, the challenges facing the Sahel region are complex, they are interconnected, but they are not insurmountable. Denmark remains a committed partner of the region. As co-penholder for UNOWAS, in partnership with Sierra Leone, Denmark will seek to maintain the Council's focus on the region. We will support the Special Representative of the Secretary-General in carrying out his important mandate.

We look forward to our continued collaboration with Council members, regional stakeholders and United Nations colleagues to that end.

Ms. Jurečko (Slovenia): I would like to thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Leonardo Simão and Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi for their briefings. Their remarks on the harsh realities of political, security and humanitarian developments on the ground clearly show that the Security Council benefits from frequent updates on the developments in West Africa and the Sahel.

I would like to make three points in that regard.

First, while we are concerned about the significant risks of regional fragmentation and divisions, Slovenia notes the establishment and development of the Alliance of Sahel States by Burkina Faso, Mali and the Niger, as well as their formal withdrawal from the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS). We hope the Council will soon have a chance to get more clarity on the separation process. In addition, we look forward to gaining insights on contingency planning regarding political, economic and security relations between ECOWAS and the Alliance. Given the transnational nature of the challenges in West Africa, a regional framework for peace and security cooperation must be preserved. We strongly support the efforts

of Special Representative of the Secretary-General Simão in offering good offices to the region.

Secondly, there should be no illusion about the fact that the central Sahel region faces an unprecedented terrorist threat. The grim statistics on civilian casualties and the high levels of internally displaced are stark indicators of that reality. Food insecurity and widespread school closures, depriving many children of education, further attest to the situation in the region. Entire towns are besieged or separated by barricades, making daily survival a struggle for civilians. Slovenia is deeply concerned about the reports of high levels of violence committed by Al-Qaida-affiliated Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin and the Islamic State — Sahel Province, as well as the rise of the Lakurawa group. Of particular concern is the Special Representative's reporting on an increasing threat to the coastal States of the region, especially Benin and Togo. Locally owned, regionally driven solutions will be essential for a long-term, sustainable peace. We support ongoing efforts through the Multinational Joint Task Force and the reformed Accra Initiative.

Thirdly, the international community cannot turn a blind eye to the development challenges and humanitarian needs in West Africa and the Sahel, but it must also not overlook the serious human rights violations and recurring breaches of international humanitarian law. Slovenia raises concerns about the conduct of military operations in the central Sahel, directed against non-State armed groups, which have too often led to indiscriminate targeting and unlawful killings of civilians, including members of ethnic minorities. We reiterate that all operations must be carried out in strict compliance with international humanitarian and human rights law, including through appropriate training for voluntary defence forces.

In conclusion, we express our firm support to the work of the Special Representative and his Office, including in their work related to the promotion of a whole-of-Government approach to regional challenges, the consolidation of democracy, the rule of law, timely democratic transitions and, ultimately, a culture of adherence to international law across the region, supported by accountability mechanisms. All of these are strongly linked to efforts towards peace, stability and sustainable development in the region.

Mr. Hwang (Republic of Korea): I thank Mr. Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General, for his comprehensive briefing, and Ms. Akiyode-Afolabi for sharing her views.

At the outset, the Republic of Korea strongly condemns the heinous terrorist attacks in Benin in January, and in the Niger two weeks ago. We extend our deepest condolences to the families of the victims.

Allow me to underline the following three points.

First, the increased terrorist activity in the Sahel and its expansion to West Africa's coastal States is deeply concerning. According to the 2025 Global Terrorism Index, five of the 10 countries most impacted by terrorism are in the Sahel. Burkina Faso has been the most affected country over the past three years, and the Niger recorded the largest increase — almost 100 per cent — in deaths due to terrorism. As such, we concur with the view in the Secretary-General's report (S/2025/187) that regional security cooperation is the highest priority.

Although various efforts are being made, largely at national levels, to counter terrorism in the Sahel, fragmentation in regional cooperation has been exploited by terrorist groups to expand their activities into coastal West Africa, as recently seen in Togo. Coordinated regional responses are essential to dismantling transboundary terrorist networks. In that regard, we look forward to the restructuring of the Accra Initiative and welcome the launch of new bilateral efforts to enhance joint border security.

However, the Niger's decision to withdraw from the Multinational Joint Task Force raises concerns about reversing gains of its operations to counter Boko Haram and Lakurawa elements in the Lake Chad basin area. We encourage the Economic Community of West African States and concerned countries to bridge differences for effective collaboration.

Secondly, democratic governance and inclusive dialogue are critical to sustainable development and economic transformation. Delays in transitional processes to return to constitutional order will only prolong political instability and erode public trust. Likewise, restrictions on political and civic space undermine the aspirations of the people.

In particular, the abduction and arbitrary arrest of civil society actors are grave violations of human rights and must be stopped. The suspension of media and bans on public demonstrations also severely restrict fundamental freedoms and weaken democratic governance.

The full, equal, meaningful and safe participation of women should be ensured so as to leverage their positive impact on peacebuilding processes. In that context, we commend the important progress made in the Gambia's constitutional reform process, as well as in successful elections in Ghana, which resulted in its first female Vice-President. At the same time, we urge countries in transition in the Sahel region to swiftly restore constitutional order and advance political reform through meaningful and inclusive dialogue.

Thirdly, the worsening humanitarian situation in West Africa and the Sahel, which disproportionately affects women and girls, demands urgent international attention and support. Escalating food insecurity and mass internal displacement that continue to strain the capacities of neighbouring host countries are stark reminders of the multidimensional challenges gripping the region. Climate shock further exacerbates those vulnerabilities, particularly with floods that threaten livelihoods by disrupting agriculture and damaging infrastructure.

That is why Korea contributed a total of $14 million last year to assist in addressing the crises in West Africa and the Sahel. We will continue our support, not only to respond to the most urgent needs, but also to bolster the resilience of those countries. As the informal coordinator between the Peacebuilding Commission and the Security Council, Korea also stands ready to play a constructive role in strengthening collaborative peacebuilding efforts throughout the peace continuum.

In conclusion, we express our strong support for Special Representative Simão, the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel and regional organizations for their efforts to build lasting peace, security and stability in West Africa and the Sahel. The Republic of Korea is committed to addressing these multifaceted challenges facing the region.

Mr. Sekeris (Greece) (*spoke in French*): I thank you, Mr. President, for convening this important meeting. I would like to thank Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General, for his briefing and express my country's unconditional support for the work of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS). I would also like to thank Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi for her invaluable contribution, which has enabled us to assess the status of the rights of women and girls in the region.

I would like to make three comments.

First, I would like to touch upon the continuing importance of commitment to democratic processes. I would like to congratulate Ghana on the election of its first female Vice-President in December and to note that Togo held its first senatorial election in February.

Inclusive, peaceful and credible elections promote not only constitutional order and the rule of law, but also conditions conducive to lasting peace in the region. Inspired by the participatory elections in Senegal and Ghana last year, my country, Greece, hopes that the Governments of the region, in particular Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, Guinea-Bissau, Burkina Faso, the Niger, Mali and Benin, will seize this momentum and continue to follow their electoral timetables.

At the same time, we express our concern about the limited civic space in some parts of the region. Creating an environment conducive to civic dialogue and fundamental freedoms is the foundation of democracy by ensuring that all elements of society are heard.

Secondly, I would like to address the prevailing insecurity in the Sahel. In the wake of this year's terrible terrorist attacks in Benin and the Niger, Greece expresses its deep concern about the persistent rise of violent extremism in the region. To prevent insecurity from spreading to the region's coastal States, we urge the countries of West Africa and the Sahel to adopt a coordinated approach to security challenges. In that regard, we encourage regional dialogue and close cooperation between the Economic Community of West African States and the States of the Alliance of Sahel States so as to address transnational threats in the region.

Last but not least, I would like to say a few words about the humanitarian front. While the successful operations of the Multinational Joint Task Force have certainly enabled progress, the military approach alone is not enough to tackle the root causes of violence and radicalization. In order to maintain the gains made and prevent further violence, we need to tackle the socioeconomic causes of conflict in the region, such as poverty and the lack of jobs, and to protect the rights of children and young people so that they do not fall into the trap of recruitment by armed groups.

In that context, Greece remains very concerned about the needs of children in the Lake Chad basin. A growing number of schools in the region have remained closed due to ongoing insecurity, with a serious impact on the essential human right to education, while girls and women in the Sahel continue to face a high risk of gender-based violence and displacement.

Likewise, the disastrous consequences of climate change, in particular flooding and rising water levels, are undeniable when it comes to human rights, peace and security. I wish to commend the Informal Expert Group on Climate, Peace and Security for arranging a trip to the Lake Chad basin region in December. The valuable lessons learned from that visit to Nigeria confirm the pressing need to tackle climate change as a driver of intercommunal violence and the increasing involvement in extremist groups, which ultimately only worsens the living conditions of the most vulnerable.

West Africa and the Sahel stand at a crossroads. The multidimensional challenges facing the region are complex and far-reaching. However, we continue to believe that they are not insurmountable if a holistic approach is taken. Through close coordination between UNOWAS and regional organizations, solutions may be found that could contribute to securing a lasting peace. Before I conclude, let me underscore that the Council should also send a clear message of support, unity and solidarity to the region. Greece, for its part, stands ready to consider any further involvement of the Council to that end, if need be.

Ms. Jambert-Gray (United Kingdom): I thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Mr. Simão and Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi for their briefings.

I will make three points today.

First, the United Kingdom urges support for democracy, constitutional order and the protection of civic space in the region. We welcome the steps towards a return to constitutional order in Guinea and Mali and note recent developments in

the Niger. We urge the authorities to maintain progress in their transitions and call on them to lift restrictions on political parties, civil society, media institutions and peaceful public demonstrations. We note the upcoming presidential elections in Côte d'Ivoire and Guinea-Bissau this year and call on Governments to ensure that they are inclusive and align with their Constitutions.

Secondly, the United Kingdom is concerned by the security situation in the Sahel, including terrorist groups' controlling of territory and wreaking of havoc on local populations. We reiterate our condemnation of terrorist attacks across the region, including those in the Niger on 21 March, and express our condolences with the families of the victims. We encourage the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel to continue its critical role in supporting inclusive dialogue processes, which entails responding to and addressing the root causes of violence to prevent further breaches of international humanitarian law. Regionally led security cooperation remains vital, and the United Kingdom welcomes efforts such as the standby force of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), which will enable Member States to deploy to counter shared threats. We also encourage careful consideration of security partners in the region to avoid worsening the threat posed.

Thirdly, the United Kingdom is concerned about the worsening humanitarian situation in the region. Since 2019, the United Kingdom has provided life-saving assistance to more than 16 million people in the Sahel. We encourage all parties to ensure rapid and unimpeded access for humanitarian assistance and to protect the safety of humanitarian convoys.

In conclusion, given the significant challenges that the region is facing, including challenges that transcend national borders, it is imperative for there to be cooperation, coordination and communication among the international community and the States and peoples of the region. The United Kingdom welcomes the efforts being made to bridge those differences by the Alliance of the Sahel States and ECOWAS. The United Kingdom also expresses its thanks to the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel for its work in aiding African States to promote freedom, security and prosperity.

Mr. Sun Lei (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): I thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Mr. Simão, for his briefing. I also listened attentively to the statement by Ms. Akiyode-Afolabi.

At present, the political situation in West Africa and the Sahel remains largely stable and the economy is rebounding. However, a number of challenges, such as terrorism, humanitarian crises and climate change, persist. The international community should continue providing constructive support to help countries in the region build on the hard-won positive momentum. In connection with the Secretary-General's report (S/2025/187), I would like to make the following three points.

First, the political process should be advanced through inclusive dialogue. During the reporting period, countries such as Mali, Ghana, Senegal and Côte d'Ivoire actively prepared for or held elections at various levels, and Burkina Faso and Sierra Leone forged ahead with inclusive dialogue. Nigeria and the Gambia were among the countries achieving progress in constitutional reform and the fight against impunity. The Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) has been actively engaged in mediation to promote dialogue and reconciliation, preserve the gains of regional integration and promote political stability. Those are all positive developments that must be welcomed and acknowledged. Countries in the region that are currently undergoing a period of political transition are also actively exploring effective models of governance. The international community should respect the will of the countries concerned, support them in pursuing a path of development

suited to their national context and refrain from undue interference and the exertion of pressure.

Secondly, security and stability should be maintained through regional cooperation. West Africa and the Sahel continue to be plagued by the scourge of terrorism. Revitalizing cooperation on counter-terrorism is of great significance to maintaining stability in the region. China welcomes efforts by all parties to revive cooperation on security under the Accra Initiative and the launching of joint cross-border patrols by Senegal and Mali. It supports ECOWAS in continuing to take the lead in counter-terrorism in the region. With West Africa and the Sahel at the forefront of counter-terrorism efforts, greater international support is needed to help the countries concerned combat terrorism and address its root causes. In that connection, it is important to stress that counter-terrorism efforts should be free of double standards and self-serving political agendas.

Thirdly, we should encourage improving people's livelihoods and well-being through economic development. According to United Nations projections, the West Africa and Sahel region is expected to see its economy grow by 4.1 per cent in 2025, a marked improvement as compared to the previous year. Nevertheless, the region is still home to 32 million people affected by food insecurity and a large number of internally displaced persons and refugees. Humanitarian funding is at less than half the required amount, and the economy and livelihoods continue to pose huge challenges. Instead of cutting aid, the international community should continue to lend greater support to help women and youth play a greater role and to help countries in the region achieve sustainable economic and social development. West Africa and the Sahel have long suffered the effects of climate change. Developed countries should actively honour their climate financing commitments and help countries in the region improve their resilience to climate shocks.

This year, as we mark the twenty-fifth anniversary of the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation, we are also embarking on the implementation of the outcomes of the Beijing Summit. China and Africa have always maintained ties of mutual understanding, trust, support and assistance. We stand ready to work with African countries to put what we achieved at the Beijing Summit into action, in particular the 10 partnership actions to foster high-quality cooperation between China and Africa and to promote peace through development.

We will also continue supporting the work of Special Representative Simão and the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel to achieve prosperity, development and lasting peace and stability in West Africa and the Sahel.

Ms. Evstigneeva (Russia): We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for West Africa and the Sahel, Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, for his report on the current state of affairs in the region and the activities undertaken by his office over the past three months. We support the work that the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel is performing as part of its mandate. We listened to the statement delivered by Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi in her capacity as a representative of civil society.

Russia attaches great importance to cooperation with the countries of West Africa. The past period in the region has seen intense activity surrounding the development of national political processes. A number of States have been convulsed by internal conflict, and there is a risk of violence escalating. It is our hope that the regional political elites will be able to summon sufficient will and wisdom to resolve existing disagreements peacefully and in the interests of the population.

The new architecture for regional cooperation continues to evolve. The members of the Alliance of Sahel States have taken the decision to withdraw from the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), and the Security Council must

respect that choice. The reasons that prompted Mali, the Niger and Burkina Faso to take that step are clear, namely, their firm desire to bolster their own sovereignty and their focus on addressing security challenges and safeguarding the interests of their citizens through joint efforts. While relying solely on their own forces, they remain open to cooperation with countries that are committed to equitable, mutually respectful and mutually beneficial interaction.

We welcome the development of bilateral contacts among certain countries of ECOWAS and those of the Alliance of Sahel States as part of a quiet diplomacy approach. For the people concerned, it is particularly important that a visa-free travel regime and free trade zone be preserved throughout the region. We hope that the example of forging political contacts between certain countries of the two organizations will soon be followed by other countries as well. We believe that, if the countries of the region reach agreement on shared goals, tasks and development paths, it will be possible to revive trust-based cooperation.

While assessing the situation in the Sahara-Sahel region, we must also bear in mind that the transitional Governments of the three countries of the subregion have inherited the heavy burden of past mistakes and the consequences of neocolonial policies. Following the military aggression by the West against Libya, the region became a haven for myriad terrorist elements. As is known, subsequent efforts to restore stability have turned out to be a complete failure, owing to the miscalculations of Western States, rather than the notorious ingratitude of local people, as some Western leaders would depict it.

In that context, we consider the attempts by certain countries to shift responsibility for current problems onto local authorities, which unwillingly found themselves face to face with the most dangerous terrorist groups, to be completely cynical. Under those circumstances, the decisive steps taken by the countries of the Alliance of Sahel States are bearing fruit. Mali's armed forces are systematically eradicating fighter cells in the northern and central parts of the country. In Burkina Faso, the authorities have maintained control over 70 per cent of their territory, which is significantly higher than in recent years. The Government of the Niger has managed to regroup forces and to step up its efforts to deter terrorists in the Lake Chad basin. Joint military operations are gaining momentum, including in the Gao region, and joint air forces are being successfully deployed.

At the same time, the Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin (JNIM) and the Islamic State in the Greater Sahara, which are becoming increasingly intertwined with separatist groups, including the Front de libération de l'Azawad, continue to mount frequent attacks targeting both military personnel and peaceful civilians.

One of the most horrific recent attacks targeted a mosque in the village of Fonbita, in the south-western part of the Niger, on 21 March, at the height of the Muslim holy month of Ramadan. The Council's press statement on that tragic incident (SC/16032), issued at the initiative of Russia, is a demonstration of international solidarity with the Government and the people of the Niger.

However, in the long term, the countries of the region deserve far greater international support. After all, the success of the Alliance of Sahel States will benefit the States in both the Gulf of Guinea and the Lake Chad basin, which are already suffering the consequences of terrorist attacks and large influxes of refugees. Against that background, we consider any attempts by Western colleagues to carry out a disinformation campaign designed to downplay the counter-terrorism efforts of transitional authorities to be immoral. In addition, it must be openly recognized that it is unacceptable for third countries, such as Ukraine, to finance or assist terrorists.

We must also note Washington's investigations into the activities of the United States Agency for International Development, which revealed shocking details of

official development assistance to Mali, amounting to approximately $14 million, transferred through the Agency to separatists in violation of that country's sovereignty.

Regrettably, certain United Nations agencies have also been involved in dubious activities vis-à-vis the countries of the Alliance of Sahel States. Specifically, as it turned out, when referring to the JNIM — a group that is designated on the United Nations sanctions list — United Nations representatives in Burkina Faso called it a non-State armed group, while legal volunteer units of Burkina Faso were referred to as rebels. Such deliberately inaccurate assessments could be considered to be disinformation and an attempt to legitimize terrorist atrocities, and we must strongly condemn them.

We expect the Secretariat to draw the necessary conclusions from the current situation, which imperils the authority of the United Nations and the effectiveness of its engagement with countries combating terrorism. Only verified information, primarily from the countries of the region themselves, should be used in threat assessments, and not information provided by Western-funded non-governmental organizations.

Let us also bear in mind that only Africans themselves can decide what is beneficial and what is not in terms of counter-terrorism or their political and economic development. They are guided by the opinions and the needs of their people, because they are directly accountable to them.

For its part, Russia will continue to constructively contribute to collective efforts to achieve stability in the Sahara-Sahel region and West Africa as a whole and will continue to provide assistance to the States of the subregion through bilateral channels. We will continue to support the countries of the region, enhancing the combat capabilities of their national armed forces and training their military and law enforcement personnel. We intend to expand the volumes of humanitarian assistance provided to the countries of the Sahara-Sahel region.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): Let me start by thanking Special Representative of the Secretary-General Santos Simão for his valuable briefing. We appreciate his efforts aimed at establishing contact with national and regional stakeholders to promote inclusive political dialogue and secure support for the region's economic, humanitarian and security needs. We also thank Ms. Akiyode-Afolabi for her briefing.

I take this opportunity to express our condolences on the loss of life in multiple terrorist attacks in the region, including the most recent one in the Niger on 21 March, which the Council has rightly condemned.

The latest report of the Secretary-General on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (S/2025/187) presents a stark picture of the considerable security, political and humanitarian challenges facing the region. We draw some satisfaction from the fact that there is quiet diplomacy across the region. We note that many countries in the region have either launched, or are pursuing, efforts to undertake internal consultations to promote domestic reconciliation. It is also encouraging to see the efforts being undertaken by the countries of the region to promote socioeconomic development and social cohesion. We think that the channels of communication should remain open and parties should prioritize dialogue to foster peace and stability.

The volatile security situation in the region, particularly the threat emanating from terrorism, is alarming. Of greater concern is the resurgence of militant activities in the coastal countries, which is having a cascading effect on the already dire humanitarian situation. At the same time, we must remain vigilant of other security threats, including armed conflict, civil unrest and transnational organized crime, including illicit trafficking and irregular migration, which may also have a negative impact beyond the region. In the face of those critical threats, it is imperative for the countries in the region to work together through joint actions in both the kinetic

and non-kinetic domains. The fact that such efforts have been impeded by a lack of regional cohesion, as reported by the Secretary-General, is not an encouraging sign, in our view.

Pakistan has close fraternal ties with countries in West Africa and the Sahel region. We support all initiatives aimed at promoting stability and development in the region. We take pride in our historical contribution to United Nations efforts in the past, successful endeavours to restore peace in several countries, including Sierra Leone, Liberia and Côte d'Ivoire. We also welcome the incremental progress in implementing the United Nations integrated strategy for the Sahel, particularly focusing on food systems, transforming education and youth employment.

I would like to make the following points.

First, we should extend all possible assistance to the countries in the region in their fight against terrorism and violent extremism. Adopting a comprehensive approach to counter-terrorism that also addresses the root causes is crucial.

Secondly, training and capacity-building are necessary to build the institutional frameworks of our African partners, which are at the forefront of the fight against terrorism. That includes effective border-control mechanisms to curb the illegal movement of terrorists, stemming the flow of arms trafficking, and to break the nexus of terrorist entities with transnational criminal networks. Pakistan supports efforts to that end and is willing to share its expertise and experience in that domain.

Thirdly, the international community must contribute to strengthening governance structures and building the capacity of local institutions according to their needs and priorities, based on the principle of African solutions to African problems. In that regard, encouraging inclusive political processes remains essential for achieving lasting peace in the region.

Fourthly, reinvigorating the regional approach is vital for establishing a collective security architecture to enhance cooperation on counter-terrorism, strengthen governance and tackle socioeconomic challenges. The role of the African Union and the Economic Community of West African States remains crucial in that regard.

Fifthly, the Secretary-General's most recent report (S/2024/187) highlights other significant issues facing the region, such as food insecurity, poverty, inflation and climate impacts. The region clearly requires support for economic development and stabilization, in addition to enhanced humanitarian assistance to those in need.

It is obvious from our discussions today that, in West Africa in the Sahel, the security challenges are intertwined with the wider, political, economic and socioeconomic development issues. There is no need to emphasize that that requires a comprehensive approach and a cooperative environment that aligns the national, regional and international efforts solidly behind the objective of durable peace and stability in that region. Pakistan remains committed to working with all colleagues to advancing such an approach.

Mr. Alfaro de Alba (Panama) (*spoke in Spanish*): We thank the delegation of France for organizing this meeting. We appreciate and thank Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General, for his work and for the perspectives that he shared with us from the Office for West Africa and the Sahel, whose efforts on the ground we support. We also appreciate the contributions of Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi, activist and civil society representative.

Today the threats in this region are evolving and spreading more quickly than the capacity to respond to them on the ground is. Climate change, terrorism and the struggle for livelihoods worsen forced displacement and humanitarian crises and make it virtually impossible for communities to develop comprehensively. Aware of all that, Panama deems it unacceptable that the needs of this region are

underfinanced. It is unfortunate that the resources needed to fund humanitarian management are not sufficient to cover even 50 per cent of the funds required to serve an area that suffers from severe food insecurity and that is the global epicentre of tragedies caused by terrorist groups. Those acts continue to cause deaths and displacement, thereby destabilizing the entire continent with millions of refugees and exacerbating the displacement crisis in Europe and the Americas. Worse still, terrorism has already spread to the south, and, although piracy in the Gulf of Guinea has decreased, illegal fishing and drug trafficking in the region continue to imperil global security.

Panama therefore recognizes the efforts of the Governments of the region, the African Union, the Economic Community of West African States and the Multinational Joint Task Force for Lake Chad in the quest for solutions. However, we know that there are complex obstacles, and initiatives have been inadequate. In that regard, we believe that those initiatives should be carried out in tandem with grass-roots prevention and peacebuilding strategies, which should be led by local authorities and communities, especially women and youth. Panama believes that it is urgent to promote the strengthening of cooperation with regional organizations, and it calls for the adoption of a comprehensive strategy to address the root causes of extremism, such as poverty, the lack of civic spaces and democratic inclusiveness and the lack of job opportunities and basic educational and health services — to the detriment of women, first and foremost.

Climate change is also the greatest threat to this region; hence the need to improve transboundary water management and incorporate programmes to be carried out together with United Nations agencies and local stakeholders to conserve fertile soils and promote best agricultural practices. That is how we can promote greater climate resilience and strengthen comprehensive human development.

Children and women in the Sahel face profound vulnerabilities, especially in terms of access to education, economic development and in the fight against gender-based violence and insecurity. In conflict-affected countries such as Burkina Faso, Mali, the Niger and Nigeria, women and girls face even greater risks, such as gender-based violence, trafficking in persons and forced displacement. In addition, women are the most severely affected by conflicts, limiting their participation in decision-making.

Although progress has been made on women's political participation, it is crucial to strengthen their parliamentary representation and role in civil society in order to ensure their full and effective participation in governance processes.

Finally, we urge Member States and stakeholders to renew their commitment, increase their financial support and redouble their efforts to invest in prevention. We must address problems at their root, before they do damage or spread. We know the atrocities that refugees suffer on a daily basis during their displacement and at temporary or detention camps. We believe that the best way to avoid the violation of human rights is to invest in gender-sensitive prevention and peacebuilding, but above all, to concentrate efforts on comprehensively addressing the structural causes of displacement in countries of origin. Only in that way will we achieve the necessary resilience in the most affected communities and thereby continue to enhance capacities to guarantee the self-sustainability and development of everyone in the region.

Mr. Kelley (United States of America): Let me thank Special Representative Simão for his informative briefing. We commend his efforts to promote long-term stability and peace in West Africa and the Sahel. I also thank Ms. Akiyode-Afolabi for her enlightening remarks.

I would like to make five points today.

First, as the report (S/2025/187) makes clear, there is an urgent need for improved regional security cooperation in a volatile environment. We recognize that the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) can play a key role in expanding and elevating regional diplomatic solutions to achieve regional peace and security cooperation. We appreciate the Special Representative's engagements across the region, including with the leadership of the United Nations Regional Office for Central Africa, on cross-border political and security issues.

Secondly, the United States condemns in the strongest terms the 21 March attack by the Islamic State in the Greater Sahara in Kokorou, the Niger, which killed at least 44 civilians. That attack is a concerning example of the expanding terrorist threat posed by groups in the region affiliated with the Islamic State in Iraq and the Sham and Al-Qaida, further contributing to displacement and regional insecurity. Governments are struggling to retain and reclaim control over territory and are witnessing record levels of violence against both military and civilian populations. The spillover from that escalation of attacks is increasingly being felt in coastal West Africa, and the United States believes that it is vital to increase engagement with regional partners to curtail extremist groups' expansion. In the Lake Chad region, the United States condemns the violence perpetrated and the disregard for human life shown by Boko Haram and other terrorist groups. We condemn the 24 March attack that claimed the lives of 12 Cameroonian soldiers.

While the region continues to coordinate its counter-terrorism efforts, it is clear that those terrorist groups remain a threat. The United States will continue to work with regional partners to counter those threats. Member States' efforts to counter terrorism must expand beyond security-centred approaches and include comprehensive efforts to prevent and deter emerging terrorist threats. Member States must also respect human rights and the rule of law in responding to terrorist threats. Experience has shown that it is not just the right thing to do, but it also stops terrorist recruitment and impedes accelerating cycles of violence.

Thirdly, we support the role of UNOWAS in facilitating continued dialogue between the Alliance of Sahel States and the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) on vital economic and political relations, in addition to regional security cooperation, following the Alliance's withdrawal from ECOWAS. The implications of that exit will have economic and security consequences, not just for member States of the Alliance and ECOWAS but for all of Africa.

Fourthly, we cannot discuss peace and security in the Sahel and West Africa without mentioning the crisis unfolding in the Sudan, which is also affecting the UNOWAS area of responsibility. We call on the belligerents to end the violence now.

And finally, we are concerned about the rapid escalation of the armed and political conflict between South Sudan's leaders. By all accounts, the country is on the brink of civil war, again. Another civil war in South Sudan would not only imperil the lives and livelihoods of the South Sudanese, but it would also have potentially catastrophic outcomes for the region.

The President (*spoke in French*): I shall now make a statement in my capacity as the representative of France.

First of all, I thank the Special Representative for his briefing and for the work carried out by his Office. I also thank Ms. Abiola Akiyode-Afolabi for her statement and her commitment to promoting the rights of girls and women around the world and in West Africa in particular.

France is closely monitoring the situation in West Africa and the Sahel. We are all aware of the historical, cultural and human ties that link my country to the region, including the active and dynamic diaspora on both sides. The region is characterized by its young population, its dynamism and its legitimate ambition. It is particularly

necessary for it to be able to address the challenges that hinder its development, and today we are talking about those who call for the Security Council to follow up.

First, France remains concerned about the evolving security situation, particularly in the Sahel and the Lake Chad basin, where terrorist attacks and community violence have reached alarming levels. The local branches of Al-Qaida and the Islamic State continue to expand their territorial hold. As highlighted by the report of the Secretary-General (S/2025/187), those conflicts have disastrous humanitarian consequences, particularly in Mali, Burkina Faso, Nigeria and the Niger, where the number of people in need of food assistance, internally displaced persons, refugees and victims of sexual and gender-based violence continues to increase. France is concerned about the risk of seeing those conflicts spread to coastal countries. Faced with those crises, it is up to us to work collectively, with the African Union and with regional organizations, while placing at the heart of our efforts the preservation of fundamental rights and freedoms and the strengthening of governance structures and the rule of law. France calls for respect for international humanitarian law and human rights throughout the region.

Improving the situation in the region will require a peaceful political environment and effective regional cooperation. France supports the efforts made by the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel in that regard, bolstering the action taken by the Economic Community of West African States. We will continue to support populations, while respecting the sovereignty of the countries concerned. The Peacebuilding Commission also plays an important role in assisting national prevention efforts, as it does in Liberia and Mauritania.

Conflicts and security crises are facilitated and aggravated by arms trafficking, particularly small arms and light weapons, which are responsible for most victims in conflicts. In that regard, I would like to thank Sierra Leone for organizing a meeting in the Arria format on the control of those weapons and to assure it of France's support.

Another challenge remains the consolidation of democratic practices. The United Nations has a key role to play in supporting a return to constitutional order in the countries concerned and in supporting future electoral processes. The organization in 2024 of elections that led to peaceful political alternations in Ghana and Senegal serves as an example for the entire region. Women, just like men, are actors in sustainable development and the proper functioning of societies. Their representation must be promoted and their rights defended. The consolidation of democracy will require the improved participation by women in regional political life, in line with general recommendation No. 40 of the Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women.

West Africa, already faced with considerable ecological and economic challenges, needs peace and stability to overcome them. It has immense potential. France will continue to work with all those partners in the region who wish to do so, within a framework that respects international law.

I now resume my functions as President of the Council.

There are no more names inscribed on the list of speakers. I now invite Council members to informal consultations to continue our discussion of the subject.

The meeting rose at 11.40 a.m.